

being achieved,” he points out. Clearances for land and environment, electricity connections, labour laws—all remain stumbling blocks. Enforcement of contracts is another pain point for businesses.

Rajat Kathuria, Dean of the School of Humanities & Social Sciences, and Professor of Economics at Shiv Nadar University, agrees and says that India must lower the cost of doing business. “Since our tariffs have been high, this exogenous shock in the form of reciprocal tariffs now provides us the opportunity to lower our tariffs and not anger the business community at the same time,” he says, adding that this also makes it the right time to introduce reforms.

Kathuria underlines that several domestic reforms are needed, although some, like improving logistics competitiveness, could take time. “But reforms on trade facilitation, lowering the regulatory burden, employing more government officials for regulatory easing can be done in the short term and can be very beneficial to trade and industry,” he says.

Sachin Chaturvedi, Director General, Research and Information System for Developing Countries, says India must focus on the cost, quantum and quality of production in sectors like electronics, pharma and textiles to give an edge to its exports. He also underlines that India diversify its export markets through signing of more FTAs.

Underlining the importance of predictability and rule-based order, Chaturvedi says, “India must focus on markets such as Africa and Latin America for signing FTAs. There has to be a



“The question remains whether India can fill the gap left by competing countries that have higher tariffs”

JAYANT DASGUPTA
INDIA'S FORMER AMBASSADOR
TO THE WTO



“India must tackle domestic reforms—simplifying tariffs, improving GST, and streamlining trade procedures”

AJAY SRIVASTAVA
FOUNDER, GTRI



“I am sure the pause will remain beyond 90 days pending negotiations, which should lead to elimination of the 10% tariff...”

ANUP WADHAWAN
FORMER COMMERCE SECRETARY

deeper trade focus of our FTAs, apart from just superficial issues, to include a whole plethora of issues such as dispute resolution,” he says.

The next few months will no doubt be a rollercoaster for global markets and trade. But it is an

opportunity for India to use America's “Liberation Day” to usher in a fresh round of liberalisation of its own economy. **BT**

(With inputs from Neetu Chandra Sharma, Arnab Dutta, & Astha Oriel)

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